of the Tawi Bridge alone will cost Rs 100 crore to rebuild. "Connectivity is our lifeline; without roads, fruit can't reach the mandis," says Bashir Ahmad, an apple grower from Anantnag, who has lost half his season's harvest. With traffic disrupted for over a fortnight and the repeated closures of the Srinagar-Jammu highway, Kashmir's fruit industry insiders say they are staring at losses of Rs 5,000 crore.

The ecologically fragile region is prone to natural calamities, but what made the recent floods worse is the unabated encroachment of river embankments and floodplains for commercial and residential purposes. Post-2019, the J&K government has made a major push on tourism and infrastructure development, with easy or no EIAs (Environmental Impact Assessments) helping in the smooth conversion of agricultural lands and forest lands for the purpose. Inevitably, this has only aggravated the problem.



UTTARAKHAND'S FRAGILE GEOGRAPHY

On August 5, the nation watched in horror as a viral video showed a giant wall of mud and water descend in fury and sweep away a big chunk of Dharali village in the Bhagirathi eco-sensitive zone in Uttarkashi district. IMD data says 400 mm of rain poured in a matter of hours, triggering the landslide. On its way down, the deluge also hit an army camp and Harsil village. Survivors described it as a "black wall" of debris that gave them no time to react. Some 60 people are still missing. More was to come as the month dragged on.

In September, even capital Dehradun and the holy town of Rishikesh were not spared. Late night on the 15th, a cloudburst in Sahastradhara area triggered flash floods that devastated parts of Dehradun and its surrounding areas. Homes and hotels were inundated, and even the local religious attraction, the Tapkeshwar Mahadev temple, went under, with only half of the giant Hanuman statue and the top domes of the temple visible. Tourist havens like Mussoorie were also hit, with the local hotel association stepping in to offer free accommodation to stranded visitors. Association member Sanjay Agarwal reveals, "Parts of all three main roads connecting Dehradun and Mussoorie were washed away; nearly 3,000 tourists were trapped here." Decades of deforestation, unplanned 'road cutting' on the slopes and construction along the riverbanks only magnified the damage.

The stories of apathy and untrammelled development, then, are common to these northern states. Alongside, the 2025 floods have also laid bare the fault lines of India's relief system. State governments compete for empathy; the Centre insists on uniformity. Experts have long argued for indexing relief to inflation and linking payouts to market prices. A 2023 NITI Aayog paper even proposed dynamic relief tied to IMD-certified rainfall anomalies. Nothing has moved. For now, families wait for cheques that cover a sliver of their losses. Crops, homes and lives are swept away in hours. Relief takes weeks—sometimes months—to trickle in, if at all it does.

WHAT THE NORTH NEEDS

In the last week of August, videos of massive timber logs swirling through the Beas and Parvati rivers during the floods went viral. The images exposed what activists in Himachal have long alleged: unchecked illegal tree felling in the fragile Himalayan state. On September 4, the Supreme Court took note, remarking that such quantities of timber "cannot be explained by natural causes alone". Citing the visuals, the bench warned that large-scale deforestation had amplified the devastation. Notices went out to the Centre, ministries and departments concerned, but there has been no word of action taken. The SC's remarks tell its own story of how the floods have exposed chronic weaknesses in disaster preparedness and climate adaptation.

In Punjab, poor drainage infrastructure, unchecked sand mining, and ad hoc dam operations turned heavy rainfall into a full-blown agrarian crisis. Yet the state's Ranjit Sagar Dam and the Centre-controlled BBMB have not invested in